11+ Verbal Reasoning

Verbal Reasoning Word and Meaning Mastery Guide

Advanced strategy for Henrietta Barnett, Dame Alice Owen's, and St Michael's

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

All nine question types, the exact mistake each one is designed to catch, a simple method for each, a worked example per section, and timing advice for this specific exam format.

BARNET CONSORTIA · SHARE WITH FAMILIES Verbal Reasoning · 11+

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What This Guide Is For

These exams test word knowledge and pattern recognition against the clock. Most guides tell you what the question types look like. This guide tells you exactly where marks are lost in each one and what to do instead.

Each section covers one question type: the mistake students make, the method that fixes it, and a worked example. The last section covers timing.

> *“It is not enough to know what the question looks like. You need to know exactly why the wrong answers are wrong.”*

01 Verbal Reasoning

Insert a Letter

Section 01 of 09

Find the one letter that ends the first word and starts the second. It has to work for both word pairs. The letter must make four real words in total.

1 PHASE

Start with Vowels

Start with E, A, Y, and T. These four letters answer most questions. Only work through the rest if none of them work.

1. Read both pairs before testing anything. Never test a letter on just one pair.
2. Test E, A, Y, and T in order. These are the letters that come up most often.
3. Check all four words are real before writing your answer.

2 PHASE

The Doubled-Pair Rule

The most common mistake is finding a letter that works for one pair and not checking the second. Always check both.

1. As soon as you find a letter that works for Pair 1, test it on Pair 2 straight away.
2. If it works for Pair 1 but makes a nonsense word in Pair 2, drop it and try the next letter.
3. The correct letter makes four real words, no exceptions.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Find the missing letter: GE (?) IE and TA (?) IME

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: T
- GET and TIE from the first pair. TAT and TIME from the second.
- T is the only letter that produces four valid words across both pairs.
- Testing E first: GEE and EIE. EIE is not a word. Discard.
- Testing T: GET and TIE both valid. TAT and TIME both valid. Confirmed.

02 Verbal Reasoning

Two Odd Ones Out

Section 02 of 09

From five words, find the two that do not belong with the other three. The link between the three is always more specific than it first looks.

1 PHASE

Name the Category Before Looking at the Options

If you look at the answer options first, you will latch onto the first category that comes to mind. Work out the connection from the five words before you look at anything else.

1. Read all five words first without trying to spot the odd ones out yet.
2. Ask yourself: what do exactly three of these words have in common that is specific?
3. Name the category out loud in your head before picking the two that do not belong.

2 PHASE

Push One Level Deeper

Your first idea for the category is usually too broad. Push one level deeper.

1. If your first idea is broad (animals, colours) ask whether a narrower version fits exactly three of the words.
2. In the set trout, salmon, rose, stood, peach, the connection is not fish. It is shades of pink. Salmon, rose, and peach are all pink. Trout and stood are the two odd ones out.
3. If there is no obvious theme, check word types. Three verbs and two nouns is a common grouping.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Identify the two odd ones out: FALCON, HAWK, EAGLE, TIGER, LEOPARD

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: TIGER and LEOPARD
- Falcon, Hawk, and Eagle are all birds of prey. That is the precise connection for the group of three.
- Tiger and Leopard are large cats with no membership of the birds of prey category.
- The first instinct may be animals. That is too broad: all five are animals. Push one level deeper.

03 Verbal Reasoning

Closest Meaning (Synonyms)

Section 03 of 09

Pick one word from each group that means the same thing. There are two common traps in these questions.

1 PHASE

The Tense Trap

The two words you pick must be able to swap places in a sentence. Past tense and present tense words cannot swap, so they cannot be synonyms.

1. Check both words are in the same form before you choose.
2. Discovered and find are both about finding something, but you cannot swap them in a sentence. They are not valid synonyms.
3. The correct pair must be able to swap places in the same sentence without breaking the grammar.

2 PHASE

The Homophone Red Herring

Watch out for words that sound like another word but are spelled differently and mean something different.

1. Read for meaning, not sound. If a word reminds you of another, check the meanings match, not just the sounds.
2. Bucket and pale might appear together because pale sounds like pail (a bucket). That is the trap.
3. Two words that sound alike are not synonyms unless they also mean the same thing.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Select one word from each group: (hurtful, amusement, waiting) | (boring, rollercoaster, mean)

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: HURTFUL and MEAN
- Both hurtful and mean describe causing harm or unkindness to others.
- Boring and amusement are antonyms, not synonyms.
- Rollercoaster and waiting share a theme of fairground experience but are not synonyms in meaning.

04 Verbal Reasoning

Word Connections (Analogies)

Section 04 of 09

Finish the second pair of words so that the relationship matches the first pair exactly. The type of link and its strength both need to match.

1 PHASE

State the Relationship as a Sentence

Before looking at the options, say in your head: A [Word 1] is to a [Word 2] as a [Word 3] is to... This locks you into the right relationship before the options can confuse you.

1. Say in your head: A [Word 1] is to a [Word 2] as a [Word 3] is to a...
2. This locks you into a specific relationship before the options can steer you the wrong way.
3. Common types: animal to its home, animal to its young, object to what it does, cause to its effect, part to the whole.

2 PHASE

Match the Degree of Intensity

The answer needs to match how big the difference is in the first pair, not just which direction it goes.

1. Breeze is to Gale as Trickle is to Flood. Both pairs go from weak to very strong. Stream is in the right direction but not strong enough.
2. A scalpel is used for surgery (object to function). A doctor works at a hospital (object to place). These are different types. Do not mix them up.
3. If two options both seem possible, pick the one that matches how big the shift is in the first pair.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

WOLF is to PACK as BEE is to _____

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: HIVE
- The relationship is animal to its collective group or home.
- A wolf belongs to a pack. A bee belongs to a hive.
- Colony is a near-miss but hive is the more precise and specific answer for bees.
- Swarm describes bees in motion, not their home. Hive is correct.

05 Verbal Reasoning

Compound Words

Section 05 of 09

Join one word from Group A to one word from Group B to make a single real compound word. Both parts must be real words on their own.

1 PHASE

The Independent Word Check

Both parts of the compound must work as real words on their own. If one part only makes sense attached to something else, it is not a valid compound.

1. Before testing any pair, check that both words can stand alone as real English words.
2. Dogsilver is not a word. Silver does not join with dog to make a real compound.
3. Go through Group A and Group B combinations one by one until you find one that sounds like a real word.

2 PHASE

Vocal Testing

Say the combination in your head. Real compound words sound instantly familiar. Forced ones sound wrong straight away.

1. Say each combination in your head at normal speed.
2. Real compound words sound instantly right. Made-up ones sound wrong.
3. If two seem possible, the more common one is correct.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Group A: (Ear, Shoulder, Foot) | Group B: (Bat, Ring, Bracelet)

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: EARRING
- Ear + Ring = Earring. A single, immediately familiar compound word.
- Shouldering exists as a verb but is not a compound noun formed by joining two independent words.
- Footbracelet and Footbat are not recognised English compounds.

06 Verbal Reasoning

Make a Word

Section 06 of 09

Find the middle word by using the same letter positions from the outer words. Meaning does not matter here at all. It is purely about letter positions.

1 PHASE

Numerical Mapping

Number each letter of the first outer word. Work out which position numbers make the middle word. Then use those same position numbers on the second outer word.

1. Number each letter of the first outer word: 1, 2, 3, and so on.
2. Work out which position numbers make the middle word in the first example.
3. Use those same position numbers on the second outer word to get the missing middle word.

2 PHASE

Ignore Meaning Entirely

Do not try to find a meaning link. There is not one. Focus only on which letter positions are being used.

1. The middle word does not need to mean anything related to the outer words.
2. If the result looks unfamiliar, re-check the positions. Do not change the method.
3. Only check whether the result is a real word after applying the rule. Do not guess the answer first.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

POUR (POD) BUD | LEAF (???) SIT

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: LET
- POD uses: P from position 1 of POUR, O from position 2 of POUR, D from position 3 of BUD.
- Apply the same rule to LEAF and SIT: L from position 1 of LEAF, E from position 2 of LEAF, T from position 3 of SIT.
- Result: LET. A real word, confirming the positional pattern is correct.

07 Verbal Reasoning

Opposite Meaning (Antonyms)

Section 07 of 09

Pick one word from each group that means the opposite. The two words need to be equal and opposite, not just roughly different.

1 PHASE

Word Strength Must Match

The word needs to be the full opposite, not just heading in the right direction. Cool is not the opposite of hot. Cold is.

1. The opposite of hot is cold, not cool or chilly. Those are in the right direction but not strong enough.
2. For each pair you consider, ask: are these words equal and opposite on the same scale?
3. If one word is extreme, its antonym must be equally extreme. Furious needs calm, not slightly annoyed.

2 PHASE

Use Prefixes as a Fast Track

Prefixes like un-, dis-, in-, and im- flip the meaning. Scan Group 2 for these first. If you spot one, look for its base word in Group 1.

1. If you spot a word with a negative prefix in Group 2, look for its base word in Group 1 straight away.
2. The suffix -less works the same way. Careless and careful are opposites. The suffix change gives it away immediately.
3. Scanning for prefixes and suffixes is quicker than comparing meanings. Do it first on every antonym question.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Group 1: (sensible, careless, daydream) | Group 2: (careful, decision, smart)

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: CARELESS and CAREFUL
- Careless means lacking attention. Careful means full of attention.
- The -less and -ful suffixes are direct antonym indicators identifiable in under five seconds.
- Sensible and smart are near-synonyms, not opposites.
- Decision has no matching opposite in Group 1.

08 Verbal Reasoning

Complete the Word and Homonyms

Section 08 of 09

Complete the Word: find the spelling pattern and apply it to the blank pair. Homonyms: find one word that has two completely different meanings and fits both sets.

1 PHASE

Complete the Word: Find the Pattern Mechanically

Work out the rule from the first two examples. Then apply it to the blank pair. Do not try to guess the answer before finding the rule.

1. Check whether the second word is hidden inside the first word. Stallion contains Tall. This is one of the most common patterns.
2. If not a hidden word, look for patterns like every other letter, reversed letters, or letters taken at fixed positions.
3. Apply the rule mechanically. Only check whether the result is a real word after you have applied it.

2 PHASE

Homonyms: the Bridge Technique

Work out what each set means separately. Then find one word that genuinely fits both.

1. Define Set 1: what do those words have in common?
2. Define Set 2: what do those words have in common?
3. Find the one word that fits both sets. Often one meaning is a noun and the other is a verb.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Complete the Word: (PAGE, PAID, KIND) | (LEAD, [????] SEEK)

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: LEEK
- From LEAD: positions 1 and 2 give LE. From SEEK: positions 2 and 4 give EK.
- Result: LEEK. Apply the same positional rule that produced PAID from HELP.
- Always identify the positional rule from the first worked pair before attempting the blank.

Worked Example. PRACTICE QUESTION AND ANSWER

Question:

Homonyms: Find the bridge word for (NOTICE, SEE) and (BLEMISH, MOLE)

Answer and Explanation:

- Answer: SPOT

- To spot means to notice or see. That connects to the first set.
- A spot is a blemish or mark on skin, as is a mole. That connects to the second set.
- Spot works in both contexts: as a verb (to see something) and as a noun (a mark).

09 Verbal Reasoning

Timing and Technical Notes

Section 09 of 09

These three points apply to every question type. Know them before the exam, not during it.

1

The Triage Strategy

At Henrietta Barnett School, 34 questions in 25 minutes means under 45 seconds per question. If you do not know a word, read the sentence it is in and see if the meaning becomes clear from the context. Give it 30 seconds. If still stuck, pick your best guess and move on. Wrong answers do not lose marks. Leaving a blank and getting it wrong both give you zero, so always guess.

2

Write the Alphabet Before You Start

For any letter-code question, write A to Z across the top of your paper before the exam starts. Counting letter shifts in your head under time pressure leads to mistakes, especially near the middle and end of the alphabet. Writing it out turns it into a simple counting task on the page.

3

Vocabulary to Know Before the Exam

These exams use formal vocabulary from 19th-century writing. The best way to build this up is reading Sherlock Holmes stories (Arthur Conan Doyle) or Charlotte Bronte novels. Words that come up regularly: melancholy (deep sadness), astute (clever and sharp), benevolent (kind and generous), eloquent (speaks well), resolute (determined), forlorn (lonely and hopeless), trepidation (anxiety about something ahead), diligent (hard-working).

The most important timing rule

Every question is worth one mark. Spending three minutes on one hard question means missing three to four easier questions elsewhere. Guess it, mark it, and move on. Come back at the end if time allows. This is not giving up. It is the right strategy.